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The Aesthetics of Machine Vision

Critical Terms and Ideas

edited by Kathrin Maurer, Rikke Munck Petersen, Dominique Routhier, Kassandra Wellendorf, and Kristin Veel

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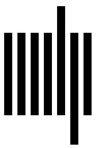
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15 Environmental Sensing

Gökçe Önal

All forms of machinic "seeing" today rely on remote sensors to obtain environmental data. In general terms, remote sensing is the science of acquiring information about a territory, an object, or a phenomenon from a distance (Lillesand et al. 2015, 1). In machine vision applications, as in any digital data acquisition technology in use today, sensors act as the "primary point of connection (some would say 'bottleneck') between the environment being examined and the image processing system" (Burke 1996, 540). Sensors retain this connectivity by converting earthbound phenomena into corresponding electrical signals, making them transmittable, quantifiable, and processable by computing devices. Being an architect preoccupied with the question of what images do, my account of machine vision departs from this "bottleneck" between worlds and machines, and positions sensing as *the* machinic way of seeing, knowing, and ordering environments. Attending to both sides of this relationship, I follow Jennifer Gabrys's (2016, vii) account of sensors as environmentally located technologies that "also in-form and 'program' environments, have environmental impacts, and take hold in particular environments, whether for managing or monitoring processes." Paying close attention to the production of sensor data, this entry thus focuses on machine vision's relationship with the broader practices of mapping, monitoring, and regulating space.

From smartphone cameras to satellite spectroradiometers, sensors are indispensable to contemporary imaging devices. To accurately define the impact of sensing on the broader practice of knowledge production, we first need to understand how sensors obtain information from their surroundings. As Michael W. Burke (1996, 5, 540) explains in his account of image acquisition systems, "visible light and electromagnetic radiation in general are the principal means of both energy transfer and communication of information. . . . Yet, information is not conveyed without a change in energy." The goal of machine vision engineering, as the author further suggests, "is to control and employ the interactions [of light and electromagnetic radiation] with matter in order to detect and sense the status, location, nature, etc., of the matter" (17). Here, the

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"detection" of matter—whether it is an indoor industrial setting, an airline passenger's iris, or a "suspicious" activity in a public space—refers to the conversion of reflected or emitted electromagnetic waves (and, less often, mechanical waves) into machine-readable electrical signals by remote sensors. Together, these "information-carrying" waves—or bands—constitute the (sub)regions of the entire radiation spectrum, ranging from visible light to infrared, ultraviolet, microwaves, radio waves, X-rays, and acoustic waves, among others. Each of these spectral regions yields a different aspect of the environment, ultimately making up the information content of images. The following paragraphs investigate the effects of remote sensing on the production of image data and its broader implications for mapping environments.

All sensors used to monitor lands, objects, bodies, or processes operate in designated subregions (or bands) of the electromagnetic spectrum. By design, sensors engage with radiant energy selectively, "seeing" the earth in fractions rather than in full. In day-to-day applications, sensory calibrations thus fulfill a targeting function that is always extractive in nature. In the case of resource mapping, for instance, where observation also results in the physical act of extraction, remote sensors target mineral deposits by the individual "spectral response patterns" of organic and inorganic elements (Lillesand et al. 2015, 21). A gold-containing ore will yield a different sensor reading than a lithium, copper, or iron reserve; similarly, a red oak will produce spectral patterns distinct from those of a Mediterranean saltbush or a dwarf banana. Sensing devices target these differences. By converting and ordering spectral layers into corresponding machine-readable—hence actionable—signals, sensors not only bring certain "immutable properties of space" into focus but simultaneously register them as clusters of data points that can be "effectively liquefied . . . into a region of transaction and exchange" (Adey 2010, 100). This conversion—from earthly radiation to computer signals—allows a series of digital operations that hold spatial implications, such as the statistical "removal" of vegetation from the ground, the "detection" and "sorting" of resources into categories, the "separation" of ores from the (electronic) soil, and the "filtering" of desired metals from surrounding ores, all the while ordering a world of profitable and nonprofitable things. Registered in the electronic soil as prospective surplus, the precious metals can eventually be "mobilized" in stock markets as (speculative) financial futures—before on-site mining even begins (Önal 2021). This representational practice of reducing, removing, and filtering the earth's image echoes the "selective blindness" that has historically shaped the colonial project of mapping and resource extraction (Bleichmar 2009, 441), which today survives in institutional applications of sensing.

As tools of institutional action, sensors are intentional devices (Anderson 2017, 7). Sensors are designed, manufactured, and deployed by the (administrative, profit-driven,

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social, disciplinary) interests of the actors who are involved in their making (Powell 2021, 154), whereas "choices in [their] production and operation . . . affect what they capture and how they capture it" (Bennett et al. 2022, 730–733). Among the largest public–private collaborations on sensor-operationalized environments today, smart city initiatives provide an interesting case where intentions—and operative ontologies—materialize in renewed practices of governance, citizenship, and representation. The "optimized" smart city prototype relies on distributed networks of sensors and a human–machine continuum of data flow to fulfill its promise of efficiency and economic growth while addressing the city as a site of "urgent environmental, social, and economic problems" (Gabrys 2016, 193). The smart city narrative typically breaks down this "'urgency" into a set of performance indicators that are made quantifiable and actionable through sensor data and its processing, such as traffic flow, waste management, energy consumption, air and water monitoring, and smart home appliances (Gabrys 2016, 207). The concept of the sensor-intensive, digitally regulated city (and buildings) thus continues to dominate governmental visions and increasingly permeates decision-making mechanisms (Farsi et al. 2020; Korenhof et al. 2023)—despite sensors' apparent limitations in measuring cultural and qualitative aspects of everyday life.

Accordingly, the question of how this urban data is extracted, processed, owned, or applied is the subject of growing criticism (Cournet and Bensi 2023; Elwood 2021; Gabrys 2016; Mattern 2021; Powell 2021). Notwithstanding their evident benefits, computational approaches to cities run the risk of oversimplifying complex and nonquantifiable phenomena into sets of sensor-measurable and statistically processable indicators. In line with their dependence on user-generated data, smart regulation systems further "convert citizens into unwitting gatherers and providers of data that may be used not just to balance energy use, for instance, but also to provide energy companies and governments with details about everyday living patterns," thus programming the environment–user–system interaction as a feedback mechanism that "transforms [citizenship] into citizen sensing" (Gabrys 2016, 189).

In terms of operationality, this trend should be read together with the practice of data fusion: the "integration of multi-source, multi-resolution, and multi-temporal earth observation data-sets" into more coherent images and models (Pohl and Genderen 2014, 164). Fused data eventually holds "information of greater quality [and detail] than the individual input images alone" (161). In the case of environmental mapping, for instance, LiDAR sensors are typically employed to obtain three-dimensional topographic data, but they cannot be used to differentiate between spectral indicators such as color or temperature. Similarly, while a multispectral sensor can be used to detect spectral features such as vegetation types, the presence of fires, or soil moisture

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content, it is largely unfunctional for measuring topographic attributes such as altitude or water depth (Zhu et al. 2018). Different sensors thus deliver different informational layers from the environment. To a large extent, this renders the information content of images a function of sensor diversity and data integration, and it offers a trope of machine vision as "a composition of regional ontolog[ies] that can know some things but never others" (Bratton 2022, 170). It is in respect of this "regional" knowing that electronic remote sensing does not support an omniscient model that sees worlds in their entirety (contrary to cultural histories of the aerial view) but instead accommodates the technique of partial registering at greater spatial, spectral, and temporal resolution.

Thinking with Lucia Oyarzun's (2018) "Nightfaring," I define this partial registering of earthly energies as a mode of seeing in a state of "cartographic overexposure"—namely, an institutionalized practice of making invisible that which is nonquantifiable, trivial, and nonprofitable. Such power relations play out differently by scale and context, as, for instance, in the case of border surveillance. What is commonly understood as an integrated system of total situational awareness at borders—when examined as a function of partially sensing capacities—reveals a series of close-range and territorial operations that target bodies and their belonging as fractions of spectral indicators. To the border-monitoring machine, human and nonhuman subjects become paradoxically near invisible, singled out as highly abstract but specific readings, including those at airports (Amoore 2006). The most commonly deployed sensing devices at airports need to "know" bodies and their belongings only as electron densities (X-rays), spectral patterns (closed-circuit television), and surface reflection coefficients (millimeter wave scanners) to sort them into the categories of risky or safe (Dinçer et al. 2021). At the building scale, these sensory interactions further materialize in the organization of space and bodily flows, as close-range and immersive modes of targeting (X-rays and millimeter wave scanners) require bodily proximities, interactions, and speeds distinct from those of long-range and territorial surveillance (closed-circuit television), resulting in different formations of the border space.

Reading these partial—or "overexposed"—registers as a function of remote sensing, we begin to understand environmental images as stacks of compatible informational layers. This compatibility is sustained by the (planetary-scale) interoperability of computing platforms, where information is made exchangeable and adaptable across computational systems "by [the] displacement of electrons." In other words, "sensors intended for the [computational] systems must speak the same language as the systems 'speak,'" which is electrical (Fraden 2016, 2). To end on a positive note, I will acknowledge this statistical–electrical (May 2019) interoperability as a specialized technique for making environments "present and interpretable," where sensing becomes

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emergent—or productive—of distinct properties and relations (Gabrys 2016, 29; Gabrys 2019b). In this science and technology studies–informed account of environments, discussed through several do-it-yourself, activist, community-based, or scientific sensing projects, sensors are investigated as enablers of human and more-than-human ecologies "within a larger project of programming environments through distributed modes of computation" (Gabrys 2016, 30; Gabrys 2019a). It is in these sites of engagement—as well as the gaps, unattributable remains, and frictions—between sense data, algorithms, knowledge, and experience that "new forms of solidarities" (Powell 2021, 19), connections, and other ways of being together can eventually emerge (Amoore 2020, 170).

As this entry has so far outlined, the practice of machinic sensing implicitly accommodates technics of targeting, extracting, making visible, and curating worlds with increasing precision. Our prominently ocularcentric—and human-perceptual—vocabulary of images falls short when addressing the materiality of machine vision in its multiple operational, spatial, and representational dimensions. Here, I align my account of machine vision with a particular line of media studies that captures the sensor-intensive condition of "seeing" in more attentive terms: as post-optical, post-lenticular (Tomáš and Parikka 2021, 17), statistical-electrical (May 2019), and, coming from a more established tradition, operational (Farocki 2004; Hoel 2018; Parikka 2023; Virilio 1994). Today, while an accelerating regime of image production and screen labor continues to shape everyday life, paying close attention to the sites of environmental sensing expands our understanding of the ways in which machinic forms of vision mediate our ways of seeing, thinking, knowing, and doing with images.

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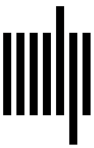
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